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Rising Prevalence of Premarital Sex and Its Correlates among Bangladeshi Reproductive-Aged Women: Evidence from Demographic and Health Surveys, 2011–2022

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Abstract

Premarital sexual behavior is still a sensitive and understudied topic in Bangladesh, where traditional norms emphasize chastity before marriage. While prior research has focused on youth and university students, little is known about the prevalence and correlates of premarital sex (PMS) among ever-married women at the population level. This study addressed this gap by analyzing four rounds of Bangladesh Demographic and Health Survey data (2011–2022) utilizing a multilevel analytical framework. PMS was measured indirectly by comparing the respondents' ages at first marriage and first sexual intercourse. The findings revealed a sharp increase in PMS over time, from 1.5% in 2011 to 27.8% in 2022, with significant variations across demographic, socioeconomic, and community-level

factors. Younger age, higher education, mass media exposure, female-headed households, and residence in affluent communities were strong predictors, whereas regional disparities were more prevalent in Sylhet, Chattogram, and Dhaka. These trends suggest shifting sexual norms, likely driven by modernization, mobility, and greater access to information. Our study underscores the need for further research on sociocultural transformations shaping sexual behavior in Bangladesh and calls for open and critical discussions on how public health interventions and educational programs can adapt to these evolving realities.

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Data Availability

Data used in the study are freely accessible from Measure DHS.

Code Availability

Syntax is available upon request from the authors.

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Ethics declarations

Conflicts of interests

The authors have no competing interests to disclose.

Ethical Approval

This study extracted de-identified data from the Bangladesh Demographic and Health Survey, which was conducted using the Measure DHS. Therefore, ethical approval was not required. However, the Measure DHS obtained ethical approval before conducting the survey.

Additional information

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